

Victoria, King George V and King George VI. I also have bank notes from the time of George VI,” says Bajpai, admitting that the first set of currency notes issued post-independence are some of his favourites as his father was born in 1947.

Of course, his collection is not restricted to only historical coins and currency. “I also have currency from various countries. It’s been collected over the years as either I or the family travelled. I even asked relatives to bring back some currency from their travels abroad,” smiles Bajpai who has nearly 700 coins.

Over the past few years, as ixigo has grown, he hasn’t been able to devote as much time to coin collecting. Today his biggest passion is technology. “I love discovering and interacting with anything new. I have been playing a lot with all the new AI tools. But things are moving so fast. One day in the AI world is like many years in technology,” says Bajpai.

ixigo, launched 16 years ago, posted a revenue of ₹380 crore in FY22. Bajpai expects to cross ₹500 crore in revenue in FY23. “In the next one year we will continue to have demand higher than supply. We will tap into that with growth. We also have new verticals in the pipeline,” he says. ixigo recently launched its EV bus service between Bengaluru and Tirupati. “We have pan-India expansion plans. We want to have 1,000-plus buses by 2026-end.”

Bajpai believes EV is the future of ground travel. He says while India is on track for the rail network to be completely electrified in the next three years, it has a long way to go in terms of buses. “Governments have to work on making intra-city travel by EV buses.”

So what’s the future for ixigo? “We are relevant for the transportation bit already but can we be relevant for more? That’s what we need to answer,” says Bajpai. **BT**

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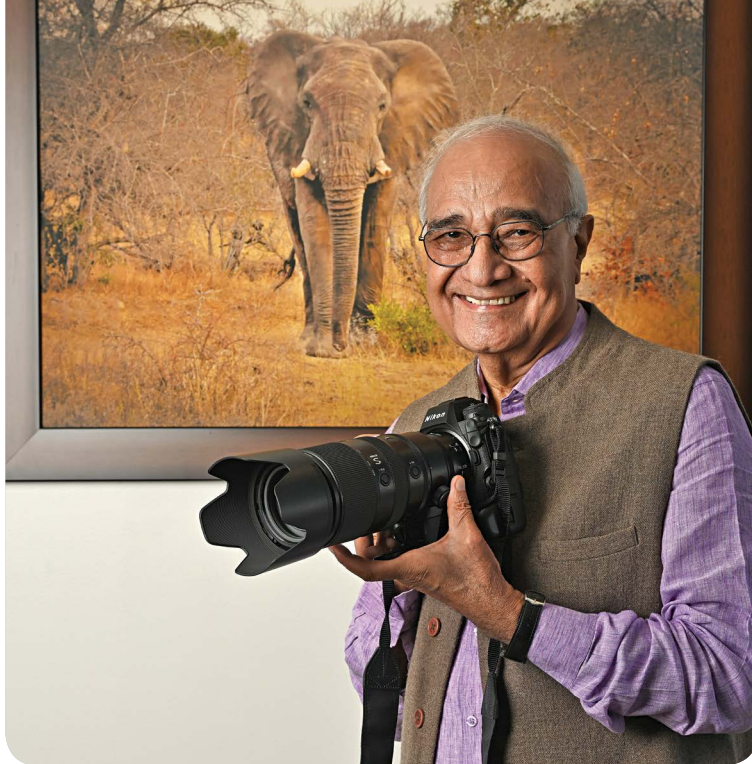


PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR

FRAMING IT RIGHT Singh loves shooting at national parks. Kruger in South Africa is a favourite

SHOOTING STAR

L.C. Singh, Founder of Nihilent, enjoys photography and clicks nature in all its beauty

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

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L.C. Singh, the 74-year-old Founder of global consulting and services company Nihilent, is an avid photographer. “By training I am an engineer but I have always had a lot of respect for the right side of the brain,” he smiles, adding that he got interested in photography nearly 15 years ago. “I am fascinated with nature and how it is able to hide engineering. Sophisticated models covered beautifully. So it is my fascination with nature that led to photography,” he says.

Singh only shoots nature—landscapes, birds and wildlife—with his Nikon Z9. “I don’t like shooting human beings,” he says. The Nihilent Founder has always used Nikon products and currently has lenses from 12mm to 1,200 mm. “I also use nearly 18 different pieces of software to process the pictures. After all, it is said that you don’t take pictures, you make pictures,” says Singh.

“The camera is unbiased. It just clicks pictures, but doesn’t necessarily create emphasis where I want it to. So when you make pictures, the focus is on controlling

the eyes of the viewer,” he adds.

Singh who likes to study ontology and epistemology, loves shooting at national parks such as Ranthambore, Pench, Tadoba etc., but his favourite is the Kruger National Park in South Africa and he goes there at least once a year.

While Singh is self-taught, he enjoys sharing his experience with others and conducts photography workshops. “In photography you get totally lost in the act. You don’t know where you are, what you are doing,” says Singh, adding that it has made him more focussed. “When I am shooting a flower I am not thinking about work then. Photography has the same impact on me as meditation. It gives me a connection with a different species. It’s a peaceful experience for me,” he says.

Even while shooting his subjects, Singh follows some principles. He never shoots animals in captivity or a flower from top. “You need to respect your subjects,” he signs off. **BT**

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